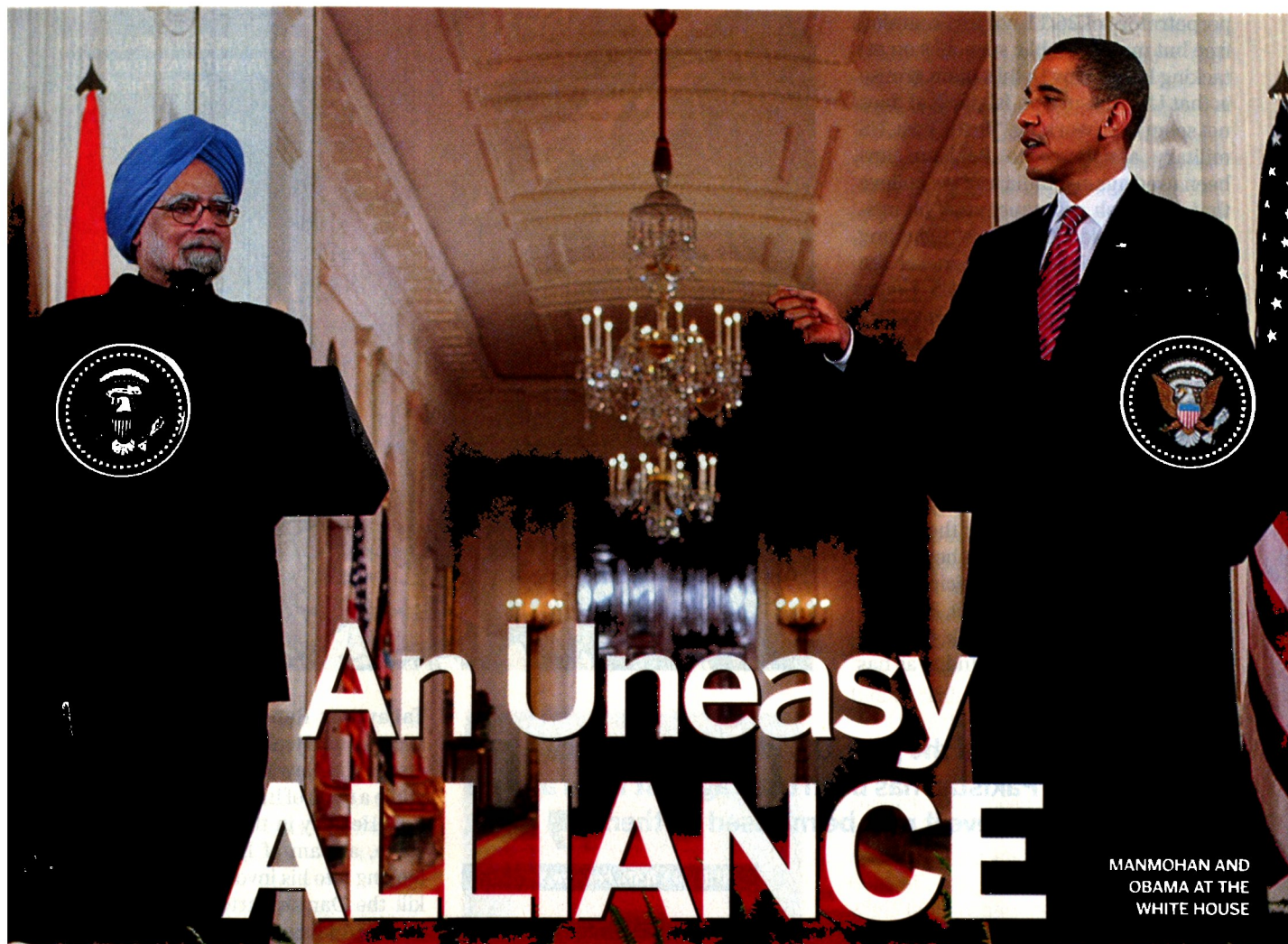




A series of issues creates friction between India and its key strategic partner, the US. The David Headley case will now show how durable the relationship is.

| By Saurabh Shukla |

Barely a few months after the Manmohan Singh-Obama lovefest at the White House and talk of a strengthened strategic relationship, New Delhi and Washington are starting to resemble a couple in need of a marriage counsellor. The welcome mat laid out for the high-level Pakistan delegation currently in the US capital has only added to the unease in South Block even as differences on key issues are straining the Indo-US relationship further. In fact, it has reached a level where Foreign Secretary Nirupama

Rao's visit to Washington last week, ostensibly for meetings of the high technology commerce group, was really focused on meeting the key players of the Obama Administration to explain that despite being an important ally, India was feeling left out on critical issues. Clearly, the relationship between the world's oldest and the biggest democracies are no longer comparable to what it was during the Bush regime. Then, the US actively lobbied to get India on board of key international forums such as the G-20 and helped break India's nuclear apartheid through the Indo-US nuclear deal. New Delhi responded by siding with

Washington on critical issues like the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) vote on Iran and opening the Indian market to US defence companies. Under Obama, the initial euphoria of Manmohan being invited as his first state guest has quickly dissipated and behind the protocol and pomp are serious issues that could affect the long-term relationship ranging from Pakistan, Afghanistan as well as Indian companies being on the 'Entity List' for export sanctions and climate change.

On top of New Delhi's laundry list of complaints is Pakistan-related terror, the widening global footprint of terror groups and the critical issue of the